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Cross-Sector Collaborations - Challenges and the Role of AI

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Cross-Sector Collaborations - Challenges and the Role of AI

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Sammanfattning

Under de senaste åren har det svenska samhället präglats av en ökning av våldsbrott, där ungdomar har spelat en central roll. Som svar på detta har den svenska regeringen, i samarbete med civilsamhällesorganisationer, inlett tvärsektoriella initiativ för att stärka det förebyggande arbetet.
Denna uppsats är en del av IBob-projektet, en vidareutveckling av det nationellt samordnade BoB-initiativet, som syftar till att förhindra att unga rekryteras till kriminella nätverk genom att förbättra samverkan mellan stora samhällsaktörer såsom Polisen, Socialtjänsten och Skolverket. IBob-projektet bygger vidare på detta genom att undersöka hur artificiell intelligens (AI) kan stödja dessa samverkansinsatser.
Specifikt undersöker denna uppsats hur generativ AI kan stärka innovationsprocesser och informationsdelning mellan myndigheter och civilsamhällesorganisationer i projekt som adresserar komplexa samhällsutmaningar. Studien analyserar de strukturella, kulturella och juridiska förutsättningarna som påverkar sådana samarbeten, samt var och hur AI-verktyg kan implementeras på ett effektivt sätt.
Baserat på semistrukturerade intervjuer med deltagare i IBob-projektet identifierar studien fyra centrala områden som påverkar och hindrar effektiv informationsdelning i tvärsektoriella samarbeten: skillnader i projektinitiering, skillnader i interna innovationsprocesser, osynkroniserade arbetsflöden samt juridisk osäkerhet. Även om ingen av de deltagande organisationerna i dagsläget har implementerat AI-verktyg på organisatorisk nivå, ser samtliga en stor potential i teknologin för att förbättra och automatisera dokumentation, utvärdering och informationsdelning. De understryker också vikten av ett tydligt rättsligt ramverk, samordning mellan sektorer samt förståelse för AI:s möjligheter, både på organisatorisk och individuell nivå.

Nyckelord: Artificial intelligens, sektoröverskridande sammarbeten, innovationsprocess, informationsdelning, organisatoriska hinder

Abstract

In recent years, Swedish society has seen a rise in violence, with youth playing a central role in this escalation. In response, the Swedish government, in collaboration with civil society organizations, has launched cross-sector initiatives to strengthen preventive efforts.

This thesis is part of the IBob-project, an extension of the nationally coordinated BoB-initiative, which aims to prevent young people from entering a criminal lifestyle by improving collaboration between major governmental actors such as the Police, Social Services, and the National Agency for Education. The IBob-project expands this work by exploring how artificial intelligence (AI) can support these collaborative efforts.

Specifically, this thesis investigates how generative AI can enhance innovation processes and information sharing between government agencies and civil society organizations in projects addressing complex societal challenges. It examines the structural, cultural, and legal conditions that affect these collaborations and analyzes where and how AI tools might be implemented effectively.

Based on semi-structured interviews with participants in the IBob-project, the study identifies four key areas that affect and hinders information sharing in cross-sector collaborations: differences in project initiation, differences in internal innovation processes, misaligned workflows, and legal uncertainty. While none of the participating organizations have implemented AI tools at the organizational level, all recognize the technology's potential to improve and automate documentation, evaluation, and information sharing. They also emphasize the importance of a clear legal framework, cross-sector alignment, and both organizational and individual understanding of AI's capabilities when implementing AI.

Keywords: Artificial intelligence, cross-sector collaborations, innovation processes, information sharing, organizational barriers

Foreword

I would like to express my sincere gratitude to my supervisors Susanne Nilsson and Rob Comber, for their continuous support, guidance and valuable feedback throughout the course of this thesis. Their expertise and encouragement have greatly contributed to the progress of my work. I would also like to thank all participants who have contributed their time and insights through interviews with great engagement. Your perspectives provide crucial depth to the analysis and made this thesis possible. This thesis is as much a result of your contributions as it is of my efforts.

Carl Lundborg
Stockholm, June 2025

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1. Introduction

1.1 Background

In recent years, Swedish municipalities have been facing enormous challenges in regards to an increase in youth affiliated with gang activities and social exclusion (Brottsförebyggande rådet (Brå) 2023). Across local, regional, and national levels, several actors are dealing with the outcomes and police, social services, and several civil society organizations are working together with municipalities to stop this development (Regeringen 2023). Initially, the Bob-project was created as a governmental initiative to enhance cooperation and streamline information sharing between governmental actors like the Police, Social Services, the National Agency for Education etc. when trying to prevent the recruitment of youths to gangs and overall trying to hinder youths from committing crimes linked to organized crime. By strengthening the collaborations and by creating a national framework for cooperation for the involved actors, the goal is to show a unified front with an efficient work flow (Regeringen 2025). However, the heavy bureaucracy and size of the challenge, together with challenges regarding information sharing and differing goals between the organizations leads to inefficiencies among all included actors. Therefore, the IBob-project was initiated in parallel to the Bob-project, looking into how an AI based knowledge database can be implemented to smoothen information sharing in cross-sector collaboration and thereby trying to create a national framework for better information sharing between different organizations (Vinnova 2024). In short, Bob is a collaboration structure on a national level with mainly governmental organizations (GOs) involved, while IBob is looking into how AI can better the innovation and improve information sharing in collaborations where both GOs and civil society organizations (CSOs) are involved. As mentioned by Nilsson and Ritzén (2023) when trying to solve complex societal challenges there exists a need for innovative ways of collaboration and information sharing including all involved actors. The use of cross-sector collaborations is mainly to increase the innovation within this type of complex issues.

At a more general level, using cross-sector collaborations can create both opportunities and challenges. This type of collaboration allows for a broader approach to societal problems with more perspectives taken into account. The challenges associated with cross-sector collaborations often come from differing organizational structures and division of roles and responsibilities (Babiak and Thibault 2007). Moreover, it is a complex and difficult task trying to create efficient collaborations between GOs and CSOs, especially when sensitive information is a part of the project (Centre for Information Policy Leadership 2023).

The rapid advances in technology and especially in AI is already changing most sectors. As AI can analyze large datasets and atomize processes new possibilities in administrative roles are made and more efficient ways of managing workload can streamline the work. Moreover, the advantages of AI has proven to be helpful in several policy making decisions and in the communication processes between different actors (Haefner et al. 2020; Füller,

Hutter, et al. 2022). The capability of rapidly scanning large amounts of data results in better prognosis and more accurate actions, for instance when applied in a clinical domain the algorithms and patterns found by AI are often beyond human capabilities (Khalifa and Albadawy 2024). However, the implementation of AI on a larger scale in a cross-sectorial setting including both GOs and CSOs remains a relatively uncharted area. Ethical and legal perspectives have to be accounted for in a broader view compared to when AI is used in privately owned settings. This affects the utilization and implementation of AI in grand challenges where the government is involved (De Sousa et al. 2019; European-Union 2021).

From a theoretical perspective, the development of innovation processes in a governmental setting requires balancing new short and long term solutions with already existing social structures in the society (De Sousa et al. 2019). In the current climate, where violent crimes are common, municipalities and their partners must implement new ideas regarding ways of working to shift the trend of increasing violence within its borders. By looking into how the organizations are currently structured around information sharing, management strategies, innovation processes, and utilized methods an understanding of the organizations work flow is created. Furthermore, by interviewing several organizations, a possibility to find a linkage between the different organization is found. This combination, of understanding the organizational structures and relationships, will help in bridging the gap in the potential of integrating AI into the workflow of the organizations which will help smoothen and speed up the collaboration between organizations.

To get a fair understanding of the problem, a qualitative research method was utilized with semi-structured interviews with representatives from the different organizations. The interviews were compared to existing literature to get a just and fair understanding of the organizations and the challenges. By understanding the existing challenges the different organizations are facing in regards to innovations processes, the research is to identify how a generative AI facilitate cross-sector collaborations. Lastly, the research was looking into where AI can be implemented without compromising the legal aspects of human integrity.

1.2 Aims and Purpose

The purpose of this thesis was to understand how AI can be used to enable enhanced information exchange between CSOs and GOs in projects when addressing a complex societal issue. Specifically, the study aims to identify the current challenges, opportunities, and organizational dynamics involved in cross-sector collaborations, and how generative AI might contribute to creating more efficient and secure information-sharing practices across different actors. The research also seeks to explore the structural, cultural, and legal requirements for AI to be effectively integrated in such settings. By doing so, it contributes to both practical implementation strategies and broader theoretical discussions on innovation management and public sector transformation.

2. Research literature

In this section the effects of cross-sector collaborations will be discussed. Moreover, the cultural differences and legal aspects is discussed where a feeling of fear of change can hinder collaborations from evolving (Rehman et al. 2021).

2.1 Cross-sector collaborations

Cross-sector collaborations refers to the partnership between organizations in different sectors such as GOs and CSOs. This type of collaboration is widely used when society is facing grand challenges - complex, large-scale societal problems that are difficult to solve due to their complexity. These challenges include issues related to public health, crime prevention and sustainability (Hardin, Trumbo, and Wiest 2019; Gakh 2015; Brown et al. 2023; Gerton and Mitchell 2019; Ba, Nair, and Kedia 2024; Nilsson and Ritzén 2023). Further, the grand challenges are often too extensive for one governmental agency to tackle itself and it is common for grand challenges to involve several different actors from varying sectors. The use of cross-sector collaborations are common where there is a shortage in funds or competence and where there is several actors affected by the same problem (Vaughn, Schumm, and Sinagub 2003; Gerton and Mitchell 2019).

Fortier and Coulter (2021) divides the success of cross-sector collaboration into six different areas that are more or less interconnected. Out of these, the relationships, their alignment, resources and the capacity of the involved organizations strongly affect how well the partnership is working and how efficient the collaborations are. The authors suggests that when an organization has other cross-sectorial collaborations their legitimacy increased. Moreover, an emphasis must be placed on ensuring alignment between the organizations and their focus points in the projects. Lastly, the resources every organization brings to the table contributes to the total capacity of the collaboration and a good distribution of these is vital for success.

In regards to innovation processes, cross-sector collaborations can foster a healthy relationship between GOs, CSOs, municipalities, and academia. Cross-sector collaborations bring together diverse perspectives and resources which supports experimentation, knowledge sharing and organizational learning. As shown by Nilsson and Ritzén (2023), these collaborations can create new complementary innovation processes. They state that through interaction between actors the innovation processes can be divided into three - responsive, tactical, and preventative. The findings indicate that a hybrid model, which uses both formal hierarchies and flexible networks, is effective in enabling long term and collaborative innovation within complex partnerships. This highlights the use of cross-sector collaborations for both short term solutions and to strengthen the long term innovation.

Moreover, several previous studies have concluded that having formal partnerships can improve the communication in cross-sector collaborations. The difference in organiza-

tional cultures create barriers within collaborations and by openly discussing the differences and similarities, the alignment between the organizations increases. Furthermore, to better understand one another the organizations must do internal structural changes. This will streamline the workflow within the projects for all involved actors(Brown et al. 2023).

The legislative perspective must be taken into consideration in this context. Gakh (2015) discusses the importance of utilizing laws that authorize collaboration between organizations in questions regarding public health. By using laws that authorizes, rather than enforce collaboration, a degree of flexibility is embedded into the decision of how much to collaborate with other organizations.

In addition to structural and strategic alignment, researchers point to internal factors as necessary and even critical for effective collaboration. Mattessich and Johnson (2018) identify 22 critical success factors for collaboration, divided into six categories: environment, membership characteristics, process and structure, communication, purpose, and resources. Their framework highlights that mutual trust, a shared vision, clearly defined roles, and open communication are crucial for successful partnerships. These factors are especially relevant in cross-sector collaborations, where organizations often differ significantly in terms of culture, working methods, and formal duties. The authors also stress the value of using tools for evaluating the effectiveness of collaborative efforts. This model supports the idea that successful collaboration is not just about sharing the same goal but also that the actors together builds structures based on trust that enables successful collaborations. This perspectives align with Bryson, Crosby, and Stone (2015) who argues that cross-sector collaborations should be viewed as "a complex and dynamic phenomenon that should be conceptualized as dynamic system" (p.657). By doing this, the challenges faced by the leadership, namely aligning initial conditions, the structures and processes used by the different organizations the outcomes and the accountabilities will be easier to handle when a more holistic and dynamic approach is taken.

Furthermore, the relationship within cross-sector collaborations differ in many ways from a strict business-to-business (B2B) partnership. With a lower willingness to share organizational structure, goals and culture the cross-sector collaborations have different processes and ways of working. Additionally, cross-sector collaborations prioritize benefits to society whereas B2B focuses on enhancing the firm's competitive advantages (Murphy, Perrot, and Rivera-Santos 2012). This is supported by Füller, Hutter, et al. (2022) stating that from an organizational perspective, the main challenge in innovation lies in designing processes and structures that are best suited to the specific task and time. Today, it is common for organizations to adapt widely used models and tailor their innovation practices to their unique circumstances—such as their industry, size, or competitive position.

Knowledge sharing within organizations is discussed by Fan and Beh (2023), stating that there are mainly three factors that have an impact on the degree of knowledge sharing within organizations, namely the role of management, organizational climate, and technological infrastructure. Having a management promoting knowledge sharing with an overall culture of sharing what you know and a data base which makes sharing

easy, will ensure a smooth flow of information and knowledge. Castaneda and Cuellar (2020), on the other hand, found that knowledge sharing is essential for organizational innovation with dialogue and collaboration being the main drivers for knowledge sharing within organizations.

2.2 Implementing AI in Governments and Organizations

The use of AI has evolved significantly in the last decade, from being a specialized research field to a tool widely used in different industries and sectors (Agrawal, Gans, and Goldfarb 2019). Advances in deep learning contributed to the successful utilization of AI in healthcare, sustainability work, technology, and finance where processes like optimizing drug discovery, transportation, autonomous driving and resource allocation have led to new findings, almost unimaginable for humans to discover (European Parliament 2024; Mhlanga 2021).

On the other hand, the utilization of AI brings challenges, especially regarding the ethical and legal perspectives as well as the biases connected to the algorithmic nature of AI (Parliament 2024; Medaglia, Gil-Garcia, and Pardo 2021). In the private sector, AI is usually associated with competitive advantage; however, in an governmental setting it has previously been a way for governments to benefit the citizens. However, studies have shown that the implementation of AI into governments still have more of an "efficiency in administrative work" perspective rather than a "impact on the society"-perspective where "Public Order and Safety" was the only area where the impact on the society was ranked higher than the administrative efficiency (Misuraca, Noordt, and Boukli 2020).

In later years, a shift in policy has taken place in the EU where more focus is placed at ensuring other strong competitors, such as the US and China, do not get too far ahead in the research and utilization of AI. While the advantages of AI are many, the challenges of implementing AI without compromising the integrity of the citizens are vast. In law enforcement this means that AI-tools may not discriminate or show bias in biometric identification (European Commission 2021). Here, the challenges of keeping experts is a problem for governments. The private sector offers a higher salary and give other benefits to gather expertise and thereby making it harder for governments to stay competitive (Surya 2019).

As a part of the work with implementing AI into organizations where personal information is being handled, the trustworthiness of the AI must be high. The efficiency of a trustworthy AI is that it is connected to the organization as a whole and that any failure can be associated to the organization and not the AI (Cousineau, Dara, and Chowdhury 2024). This view is supported by (Kinney et al. 2024) who emphasizes the media's role in portraying AI as a technology that can solve almost any problem. The view of AI being this capable will then lead to the loss of trust in AI, and the organizations using it, when it can not do what is expected of it. This discrepancy has led to governmental actors such as the EU and the International Organization for Standardization to formulate definitions and guidelines of AI, the utilization and its purpose (International Organization

for Standardization 2018; European Commission 2019). Moreover, the trustworthiness of AI is closely related to ethical principles such as fairness, transparency, safety, and accountability (Goldsteen, Farkash, and Hind 2024).

Building on this, Lee and Dourish (2024) explore how data and AI initiatives in local governments are shaped both by how the technology is designed and by the dynamics surrounding it, such as culture and organizational boundaries. They describe that in these types of initiatives the organizations have to deal with conflicting values, differences in power, and the internal structure in the organizations. Their findings points out that for AI to be meaningful and integrated smoothly into governmental institutions, attention must be paid to the political dimensions of data, how it is interpreted and used within and between institutions. This reinforces the idea that successful AI implementation requires strong infrastructures and policies as well as a deeper understanding of the cultural context in which these systems are to be used. This argument is supported by Kawakami et al. (2024) who examines how decisions around AI design and implementation in the public sector are shaped by a more or less complex network of power relations rather than just the technical aspect. They conclude that choices regarding AI systems are usually strongly dependent on the hierarchical settings, internal politics, and existing norms.

While these considerations are particularly relevant for governments, there are additional factors that must be addressed to ensure the safe and effective implementation of AI in the public sector. Berryhill et al. (2019) points to several key components - firstly, governments should develop clear strategies supported by flexible structures that prioritize the needs of their intended end user. Having and including diverse perspectives is essential for designing systems that work well for the end users. Secondly, the use of AI must be grounded in well-defined legal frameworks and controlled data management, where human oversight is needed to ensure data quality and privacy. Lastly, long-term investments are needed in the development of skills and cross-sector collaborations. These investments should be a part of a forward-looking strategy, aimed at trying to anticipate and prepare for AI's future impact within the public sector.

The integration of AI into innovation management is expected to transform how innovation is structured and executed. Tekic and Füller (2023) emphasize the importance of data and data collection, as AI systems base all insights on data quality. This shift increases the need for collaboration, especially with external actors who can provide high quality data. AI is also expected to become a core team member in innovation instead of just a tool, with humans making decisions based on AI-generated suggestions. Füller, Tekic, and Hutter (2024) support this view, highlighting four areas where innovation management must adapt: strategy, organizational setup, roles and skills for innovation, and collaboration. Strategically, organizations must move beyond using AI as a trend and instead implement it as a fundamental part of the business strategy and integrate it into its culture. Doing this requires having processes with clear goals and ways of working. Organizational structures need to be more agile and cross-functional, having teams centered around the capabilities of AI. This will allow for faster task and resource allocation regarding what AI should handle and what should be dealt with by humans. The roles within innovation teams are shifting as well. AI implementers such as data scientists and engineers build and maintain AI systems, while AI complementors ensure those systems

meet the needs of the organization. The collaboration between these roles is vital for maximizing the outcomes for innovation. Finally, when AI is involved the collaboration extends beyond the traditional view of partnerships. Engaging with nontraditional stakeholders such as hospitals, universities, and public institutions is a must to stay relevant. Managing these relationships requires new models for using data in an ethical manner, sharing information that will benefit both actors, while balancing capabilities of AI with human insight to maintain responsible and impactful innovation.

Based on the reviewed literature, it becomes evident that cross-sector collaborations face complex challenges related to innovation management, cultural alignment, and information sharing. At the same time, the rapid development of AI offers new opportunities for enhancing these collaborations. However, the practical and ethical implications are still not fully understood. Therefore, to address these gaps and to gain a deeper understanding of the dynamics within cross-sector collaborations that involve both governmental and civil society actors, the following research questions have been decided on:

- What are the challenges involved in innovation processes in cross-sector collaborations, and how is information exchanged between the involved actors?
- What role can artificial intelligence (AI) play in supporting collaboration and information exchange in cross-sector innovation initiatives?

3. Methodology

3.1 Research setting

This thesis is part of a larger research project, the IBob-project, botho of which aims to explore how generative AI can support cross-sector collaboration between CSOs and GOs to address complex societal challenges. The IBob-project originates from the earlier nationwide Bob initiative that was created to establish a permanent collaborative structure where social services, the police, and other relevant actors work together to prevent young individuals from being recruited into criminal networks, with a strong emphasis on early identification and coordinated interventions (Brottsförebyggande rådet 2024).

Sharing information from government agencies to civil society in not as straightforward as it may seem, as several laws regulate the extent to which such information is allowed to be disclosed. Below is a description of the regulatory acts within the Swedish GOs.

The collaboration and information sharing between social services and other actors is mentioned in the Social Services Act (Socialtjänstlagen, SFS 2001:453 (2025), which outlines the obligations of the social services in municipalities to engage in efforts with other institutions to support individuals in need. When it comes to the handling of personal data, this act refers to the Public Access to Information and Secrecy Act (Offentlighets- och sekretesslag, SFS 2009:400 (n.d.). According to this law, information about an individual's personal circumstances may only be shared if it is clear that doing so will not cause harm to the individual or anyone closely related to them.

On April 1, 2025, the Swedish government introduced a new law aimed at promoting collaboration between Social Services and other authorities when young individuals are at risk of becoming involved with criminal networks. The new law, Act on the Obligation to Provide Information to Law Enforcement Authorities (Lag on skyldighet att lämna uppgifter till de brottsbekämpande myndigheterna) (2025), is a step toward ensuring transparency between the involved actors and ensures information is shared when necessary and is thereby supporting crime preventing efforts. While the new law intends to strengthen coordination and collaboration, its effectiveness will largely depend on how it is interpreted and applied.

Furthermore, a new modernized and updated version of the Social Services Act is set to be implemented on July 1st 2025 (Socialstyrelsen 2025). The new version focuses on preventative efforts, improved collaborations and is intended to better respond to the challenges present in the society today. Moreover, social services are assigned clearer responsibility for crime prevention, particularly among children and youth. At the time of writing, the law has not been implemented and its impact on the operational activities of the police and social services cannot yet be assessed. Its full effect and how it will be applied by individual officials remain to be seen.

3.2 Method

To get a deeper understanding of the problem at hand, a qualitative research methodology was chosen which was based on a qualitative and exploratory case study design (Brinkmann and Kvale 2018; Tight 2017). The IBob-project itself serves as the case study, which provides insights into the innovation processes and collaboration challenges faced by the participating organizations.

The data was collected through semi structured expert interviews conducted with representatives from different organizations participating in the IBob-project (see section 3.4) (Bogner, Littig, and Menz 2009). The representatives have a leading role within their own organizations and have a deep understanding of the methods currently being utilized. By conducting the interviews this way, a detailed picture of how the different organizations within GOs and CSOs deal with innovation, information sharing and the implementation of AI. Out of ten interviews, two were held in person (Skyddsvärnet and the youth worker) and eight were held as a video conference. All interviews were recorded using a phone and thereafter transcribed using Word. Moreover, the interviews ranged between 50 to 120 minutes in length, allowing for deep exploration of the organizational processes and challenges.

Moreover, as part of the IBob-project, several workshops where discussions regarding the use of AI have been held with the involved actors. These workshops have contributed to a broader understanding of the participating organization's perspectives on cross-sector collaboration and AI implementation. The result of these discussions are presented in section 4.4.2.

Besides this, a literature research was conducted to help connect the results from the interviews to existing research focusing on cross-sectorial collaborations, management innovation, and AI implementation.

3.3 Data Analysis

The interviews were transcribed and analyzed by dividing the answers into themes based on reoccurring patterns (Braun and Clarke 2006; Byrne 2021). By generating code and iteratively searching for themes, four themes were found with eight sub-themes (see figure 4.1), these describes the patterns mentioned across the organizations. Focus was placed on understanding how the organizations perceive the role of AI within innovation processes and what factors are affecting its implementation. Moreover, the validation of the result was done through comparing the answers from the interview with the literature. Furthermore, an iterative analysis were done where insights was discussed with experts in the field.

3.4 Data Collection

As part of the IBob project, several actors from both the public and civil society sectors collaborate to address the complex challenges associated with crime prevention and pre-

venting youth from joining gangs. These actors contribute with different perspectives, resources, and areas of expertise. GOs such as the Police and Brottsförebyggande rådet (Brå) provide tools for legal and analytical expertise, while CSOs offer insights in the local aspects of the issue. The role of municipalities is mostly focused on implementing and adapting strategies to local conditions. Below is a presentation of the actors involved in the project and their respective roles. Moreover, to ensure a broad view of the ways of working, some organizations that are not part of the IBob-project have been interviewed.

For the interviews, two interview guides were used which can be found in appendix A and B. Appendix A has a deeper focus on the organizational structure, internal work methods, AI usage, and innovation processes and was used for the GOs and CSOs. Appendix B was used for the school and after school- center and was focusing on the processes of working with the youth at risk and collaboration with the social services.

The interviews were conducted with representatives from the organizations described in table 3.1. Below is an description of the participants, focusing on their roles, backgrounds, and relevance to the study.

Moving forward, the GOs are defined as the Social Services and the Police, the CSOs are Initcia, Skyddsvärnet, Göteborgs stadsmission and the municipalities are represented by Järfälla municipality. The representatives from the school and after-school center in vulnerable areas have a limited addition to the thesis.

Table 3.1: Description of involved and interviewed organizations. (A) or (B) refers to interview guide in appendix A or B.

Organization	Description of organization	Description of Representative	Part of IBob
Police (NOA)	The National Operations Department of the Swedish Police Authority, responsible for coordinating national and international law enforcement efforts, intelligence analysis, and specialized crime-fighting initiatives.	(A) The Police Authority was represented by a senior official, responsible for interagency collaboration at a national level. This participant has extensive experience coordinating assignments given by the government across national, regional, and local levels. His participation provides valuable insight into how GOs structure collaboration and manage cross-sector partnerships.	Yes

Table 3.1: Description of involved and interviewed organizations. (A) or (B) refers to interview guide in appendix A or B.

Organization	Description of organization	Description of Representative	Part of IBob
Initcia	A civil society organization focused on social innovation and entrepreneurship, working to create opportunities for individuals facing challenges in the labor market.	(A) Initcia contributed two participants: an operations manager with long experience in social innovation initiatives and a project coordinator who was recently recruited for the IBob-project. Their participation offered both a strategic and operational perspective on how CSOs manage innovation processes and work with complex societal challenges.	Yes
Järfälla Municipality	A municipality located just north of Stockholm city, heavily affected by violent crimes and gang activity (Polismyndigheten 2023). The municipality is actively working to reduce the high rate of criminal activities	(A) Järfälla Municipality was represented by the community safety coordinator, a professional working with operational safety measures and strategic planning within a municipality heavily affected by gang related activities. The participant provided valuable input on municipal working methods and the challenges involved in implementing preventive measures at the local level.	No
Göteborgs Stadsmission	A nonprofit civil society organization in Gothenburg that provides social support, housing assistance, and integration services for vulnerable individuals and families.	(A) Göteborgs Stadsmission was represented by a manager within the labor integration department. This participant shared experiences from working directly with vulnerable populations and emphasized the importance of cross-sector collaboration in crime prevention efforts.	Yes

Table 3.1: Description of involved and interviewed organizations. (A) or (B) refers to interview guide in appendix A or B.

Organization	Description of organization	Description of Representative	Part of IBob
Skyddsvärnet	A nonprofit civil society organization that offers support, rehabilitation, and reintegration services for individuals at risk of social exclusion, including those with criminal backgrounds or substance abuse issues.	(A) Skyddsvärnet was represented by two individuals: an organizational development manager and a project manager responsible for coordinating activities within the IBob-project. Both participants offered perspectives on working in CSOs with a focus on social integration of individuals. Both participants highlighted the specific challenges faced by nonprofit actors when collaborating with governmental institution.	Yes
Social services in Täby Municipality	Representatives of the Youth Crime Response Team in Täby municipality. Working with a new method, driven by joint efforts between the police and social services.	(A) Täby Ungdomsjour was represented by a youth counselor with extensive experience working directly with at-risk children. The participant offered valuable insights into the everyday realities of frontline social work, highlighting the importance of building relationships and trust in preventive efforts. She outlines the social services' perspective on the issue, including the methods employed and the legal constraints related to sharing personal information. The interview also highlights structural limitations and legal factors that can hinder effective collaboration with public authorities.	No
After-school center in a vulnerable area [1]	Representatives from the after-school center in a municipality of Stockholm working directly with youths living in a vulnerable area with a high crime rate.	(B) The school located in a vulnerable area was represented by a principal who manages educational efforts directed at students at risk of social exclusion and criminal recruitment. This participant provided insights into how schools interact with social services and the police, and the barriers that exist for effective collaboration	No

[1] See: https://polisen.se/om-polisen/polisens-arbete/utsatta-omraden/

Table 3.1: Description of involved and interviewed organizations. (A) or (B) refers to interview guide in appendix A or B.

Organization	Description of organization	Description of Representative	Part of IBob
School in a vulnerable area	Representatives from the school working directly with youths living in a vulnerable area with a high crime rate.	(B) The after-school center in a vulnerable area was represented by a youth worker with several years of experience supporting at-risk youths in environments characterized by high levels of social exclusion and crime. This participant offered a broader perspective on preventive work and the effects of the efforts have on the youths at risk.	No

In addition to the actors mentioned above, several other stakeholders were involved in the BOB and IBob-projects. Researchers from KTH - The Royal Institute of Technology - contribute with analytical expertise within the IBob-project. The consulting firm Konkret, which specializes in integrating AI into organizations also played a key role. However, these two were not interviewed as a part of this thesis.

Together, the organizations and participants offered a wide perspective with GOs, CSOs, and local actors working directly with affected youths. Their collective experiences contributed to a wide understanding of the operational and structural barriers involved in cross-sector collaboration, but also the difficult dynamics of trust, legal interpretation, and organizational culture. Importantly, the participants' reflections also contribute to a deeper understanding of how AI could be implemented to support information sharing, improve coordination, and strengthen the efforts in cross-sector collaborations.

3.5 Limitations

Throughout the thesis several limitations were found. As a case study, the data collection was limited to the organizations involved in IBob, therefor the results were to some extent specific to these organizations. Moreover, the perceived and observed challenges are connected to the experience of the interviewed representative of the organizations. However, this limitation was minimized as the representatives have a profound knowledge and understanding of the challenges linked to youths in organized crime (Bogner, Littig, and Menz 2009).

Furthermore, as the study had a focus on the methods used by the organizations and the innovation processes utilized by them, the technical aspect of AI was put aside. This could limit the insights regarding the implementation and use of different AI-models.

There is a rapid shift regarding several of the areas this report was looking into. Several new laws have come into effect during the time of writing. These were meant to improve and simplify the work and information sharing when working with hindering youths from joining gangs. Moreover, a societal shift in accepting AI in day-to-day operations was

taking place meaning that some of the results might become outdated if this change continues.

4. Empirical observations

As part of the methodology, several interviews[1] were conducted to get a deeper understanding of the challenges and opportunities surrounding cross-sector collaborations and the implementation of AI-tools to streamline the information sharing. The following chapter describes the empirical observations found through the interviews and the themes found as a result of them.

Four themes were found to be affecting the information sharing in cross-sector collaborations (see figure 4.1): the innovation process model used when they are not in collaborations, the way of initiation of projects, the workflow in non-cross-sectorial collaborations, and the interpretation of the legal frameworks. The first three are a part of the organizational structure and culture and the fourth is the legal standpoint affecting GOs more than CSOs.

Moreover, the implementation and potential of AI into cross-sector collaborations, two reoccurring factors were mentioned: the level of AI in use today and the potential of AI. This will be described in detail below.

4.1 Innovation Process Models

The interviewed organizations mentioned following different types of innovation management processes. Initcia, Göteborgs stadsmission, and Täby Ungdomsjour expressed not using any sort of innovation process. Instead, they described a reactive approach, where practices are developed and adapted in real time as problems emerge. Rather than working from established frameworks such as design thinking, agile, or stage-gate models, these organizations rely on experiential knowledge and intuitive decision making.

> No, not in a formal sense. We don't use design thinking or agile methods in that way. Our work is very operational and constantly adapted to the situation. Of course, we have goals and plans, but much of what we do has to be flexible – it's about people in urgent situations, and it's not always possible to follow a fixed process. - Ungdomsjouren in Täby municipality

The flexible workflow is presented as needed since they are working on an individual level with people in need.

Skyddsvärnet on the other hand, are trying to use "Extra Ordinary Results" (EOR), an innovation process based on setting goals and thereafter planning backwards from that. The interviewees explain that it is working well within the organization. Järfälla municipality and NOA both expressed using iterative processes with workshops and a strong sense of adaptation for the problem at hand. It is mentioned to be working well as it keeps the team updated on the situation and ensures everybody understand the upcoming assignment.

[1] All interviews were held in Swedish and all the quotes have been translated to English by the author.

4.2 Projects Initiation

The interviews revealed a clear distinction in how new projects are initiated across sectors and organizations. The CSOs are typically engaged through informal networks and personal relationships, whereas GOs often receive top-down directives regarding both strategic priorities and, in some cases, methods of implementation. This reliance on interpersonal connections makes CSOs particularly vulnerable to staff turnover, as their involvement is often strongly dependent on individual relationships.

> Reorganizations or staff turnover can suddenly change the dynamics. You might have a well-functioning contact with a certain person, but if that person leaves or if the entire department is relocated, it can lead to disruptions in the collaboration. - Initcia

Furthermore, when GOs initiate collaboration with CSOs, it is generally based on familiarity with specific individuals, rather than institutional roles, requiring them to identify and reach out to a particular person perceived to possess relevant expertise.

> It's very much about 20 years of experience and networks. Take, for example, the IBob- project that Felicia[2] is working on. That connection arose spontaneously at a private event. It was someone from Konkret whom she started talking to—someone she already knew—and they realized they were both working on similar issues. So they decided to meet and talk more. - Skyddsvärnet

In this case the initiation from the GO is dependent on individuals too and the participation of Skyddsvärnet is dependent on Felicia.

4.3 Workflows in non-cross-sectorial collaborations

Because organizations are rooted in their own processes, collaborating across institutional boundaries often leads to friction. Differences in organizational culture across sectors have emerged as a significant barrier to collaboration, particularly when it comes to embracing change. Several interviewees described how internal cultures, especially within governmental organizations, often create a strong attachment to routines. This can create barriers to external collaboration, particularly when there is a fear of disruptions in established workflows. Both NOA and Järfälla municipality acknowledged that the introduction of a project like IBob has the potential to challenge these bureaucratic methods. While there overall is an openness to innovation, there is also concern that AI or cross-sector collaboration could force organizations having to restructure and question long-standing working methods, internal structures and culture, something that may not be welcomed by all members of the organization. As a result, change is not only a question of strategy or resources, but also one of cultural readiness and the willingness to let go of institutional habits that feel safe and familiar.

> Culture and tradition can be obstacles. People tend to hang on to methods and ways of working that they feel comfortable with. There is also a certain

[2]Pseudonym for the other representative from Skyddsvärnet

> skepticism towards change, especially if it involves questioning established structures. - NOA

This feeling of wanting to stick to your existing ways of working tends to slow the innovation process down when working in cross-sector collaborations. One recurring theme is that CSOs often experience a sense of being included but not integrated into projects run by GOs. They are invited into projects to fulfill specific delivery tasks rather than being recognized as equal partners making their influence lower than their governmental counterpart. However, the view is not clearly projected to the CSOs, making their presence a bit unclear. Interviewees from Initia and Göteborgs stadsmission express frustration over being involved too late or too "lightly" in the process, with their knowledge and methods being undervalued or misunderstood. On the question of what is needed to enhance the collaboration one participant answered:

> More time and more resources for us in civil society. Right now, we often get fewer hours in the projects, which means our perspectives risk being lost. - Initcia

Overall, GOs and municipalities tend to have more formal working processes and more standardized workflows, while CSOs operate using more agile and individually centered processes. However, rather than using these differences, collaborations often enforces hierarchical structures where the GOs almost always have the most power.

4.4 Interpretation of Legal Frameworks

A recurring challenge mentioned in several interviews is the difficulty of interpreting and applying legal frameworks. This is described especially when it comes to collaboration between sectors and information sharing. Actors such as Täby Ungdomsjour, Initcia, Skyddsvärnet, and NOA all highlighted how uncertainty regarding the law, creates hesitation and slows down joint efforts. While the Social Services Act itself is often not the direct barrier, the lack of clarity and confidence in its interpretation leads to inaction.

> I do not necessarily believe that new legislation is required; rather, we need to improve our understanding and application of the exceptions that already exist. - Ungdomsjouren

Representatives from Ungdomsjouren points out the need for utilizing the exceptions within the law that is allowing the social services to share information. Moreover, civil society actors described how uncertainty around GDPR makes it unclear what kind of personal data they are allowed to receive or pass on—even when the intention is to protect vulnerable youth. There exists a frustration within several organizations with the social services as they are more restricted by the Social Services Act. This law is restricting the social services in its communication and information sharing with other organizations. The principal describes an information gap where they send information regarding youths in need of programs and a low response rate from the social services on their actions in the matter.

> That we keep raising the alarm, but nothing happens. I don't think it's

> the social services' fault – they have laws to consider. An LVU (Lag med särskilda bestämmelser om vård av unga - The Care of Young Persons (Special Provisions) Act) or SoL (Social services law) decision is required to take any mandatory action. Many parents with addictions or difficulties don't show up to meetings. There's also a major problem with socioeconomic vulnerability – children have no money, wear the same clothes every day, hoard food. This leads to misery, which in turn increases the risk of criminality. - Principal, vulnerable area.

This shows the complexity of the situation where absent parents complicates the efforts made by organizations. The law surrounding youths is, to some extent, dependent on the parents and the degree of engagement in their life.

Moreover, representatives from NOA emphasized that in many cases, actors are afraid of sharing information, not because they are legally prohibited, but because they are afraid of doing something wrong. Skyddsvärnet also noted that when legal frameworks are perceived as unclear, individuals tend to stop collaborating and avoid sharing information to reduce the risk. This results in a culture of caution in cross-sectorial collaborations, where the culture is guided more by fear than by what is stated in the law.

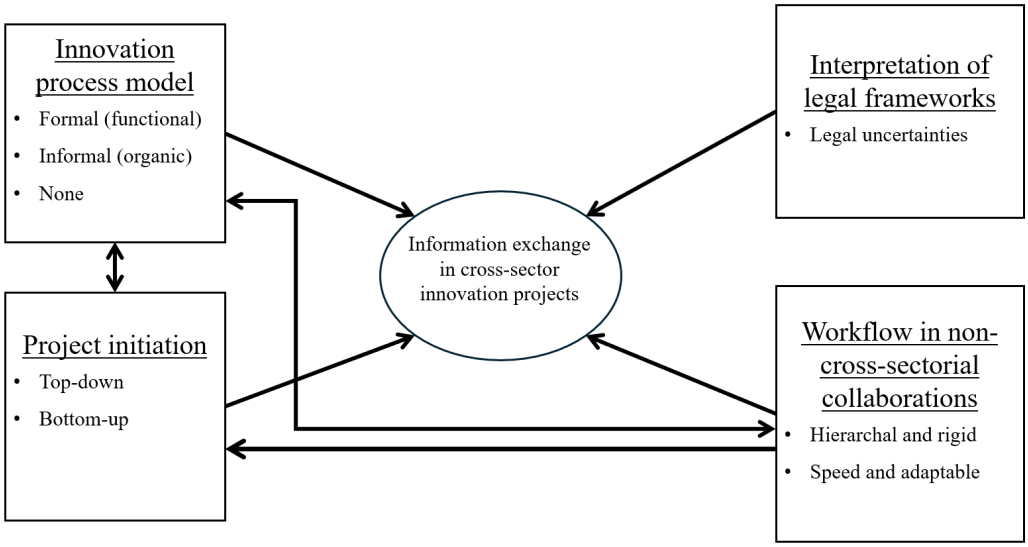


Figure 4.1: Factors influencing the information exchange in cross-sector collaborations

4.4.1 AI use today

Throughout the interviews, it became apparent that AI has not been implemented at an organizational level in any of the involved organizations. Instead, AI is currently being used by individuals who have a personal curiosity for the technology and are trying to ease the work load. This experimentation is not being pushed on by the organization. Some employees have experimented with generative AI tools like ChatGPT to assist with administrative tasks such as drafting reports or summarizing documents. However, this occurs without organizational support leading to uncertainty on how much the AI-tools is allowed to be used. Some interviewees expressed a feeling of hesitation for implementing

AI in the organizations due to concerns over data leakage, ethical dilemas, and legal uncertainties.

> Even if AI merely confirms things we already know, it can still lend greater weight to conclusions and make it easier to justify certain actions. At the same time, there is a risk that AI reinforces existing biases, as it is trained on human-generated data and decisions. We have seen examples where AI has reproduced and amplified discriminatory patterns, which highlights the importance of being mindful of how it is used. Another risk is that AI is perceived as a neutral and objective source of truth, which may lead people to rely on its decisions without questioning them. This is particularly problematic in public administration, where there may be a tendency to shift responsibility onto the technology. - Initcia

Like Initcia, several interviewees expressed caution in implementing AI to protect the privacy of the people involved. The ethical aspect in implementing AI and not trusting it without a doubt have been mentioned by several participants.

Others highlighted a low level of internal knowledge and training in AI as a existing barriers for implementing AI on a broad front. This uncertainty has led to a cautious stance, where actors are hesitate to move forward out of fear of doing something wrong when working with sensitive information.

Nevertheless, most interviewees saw great potential in implementing AI into the organizations as long as the factors mentioned above are taken into consideration.

4.4.2 The potential of AI

Despite the current lack of structured plan for implementing AI, there is broad recognition of AI's potential to smoothen the innovation processes and working processes overall. Several interviewees, including Skyddsvärnet, pointed to opportunities for AI to improve the documentation and evaluation of efforts, leading to a faster and more effective way of using the methods. Representatives from NOA suggested that AI could be used to detect patterns across datasets or to generate analyses in real time, which could be useful in social contexts. There is also interest in exploring AI as a tool for streamlining collaboration, improving knowledge sharing across sectors, and enhancing real-time feedback loops in projects. However, many emphasized that this would require the implementation to have clear legal frameworks and ethical guidelines to ensure AI is used responsibly and effectively.

Table 4.1: Description of what areas AI should be used for as mentioned by the interviewees.

What AI should be used for	Organizations
Simplify information sharing	Skyddsvärnet, Initcia
Evaluation of past efforts	NOA, Skyddsvärnet
Streamline documentation	NOA, Initcia, Täby Ungdomsjour, Göteborgs Stadsmission
Pattern recognition	Initcia,
Automating situational analysis	Järfälla municipality

Throughout the IBob-project, several workshops have occurred where discussion regarding the implementation of AI has been brought up. From them, seven areas of implementation have been mentioned:

- Information sharing and collaboration
- Recommendations of actions for individual children
- Enhanced documentation and data analysis
- Predictive analysis
- Trend analysis and learning processes
- On-boarding and competence-development
- Make the CSOs' interventions accessible to GOs

A comparison between these displays the similarities and differences such as: simplifying the information sharing, streamlining documentation, and automating situational analysis. Additionally, both the interviewees and workshops recognize the value of AI in improving evaluation processes of past efforts. Pattern recognition and predictive analysis seems to be overlapping; however, the workshops have a more descriptive and precise use where the predictive analysis is explained to be for identifying early signs of risk, enabling earlier interventions. Furthermore, the workshops suggest using AI for generating recommendations for individual children and supporting on-boarding, as well as making the interventions of CSOs more accessible to GOs. This was not brought up by the interviewees but is aligned with the needs of the GOs and could make it easier for them to choose who to collaborate with when initiating cross-sector collaborations.

The differences are most likely a result of the discussions and shows the effectiveness of having workshops when working across sectors.

5. Analysis & Discussion

The following chapter provides a critical analysis of the results presented in chapter 4, which are based on the empirical observations conducted in this study. These findings are discussed in relation to the theoretical findings presented in chapter 2. This allows for a deeper discussion of themes and the implications this has for the cross-sector collaborations.

5.1 Project Initiation - a Tension Creator

The empirical observations show a strong distinction between the formal (top-down) and informal (bottom-up) approaches to initiating projects. GOs mainly rely on formalized, top-down processes, where directives are given based on national strategies and priorities set by the government. In contrast, CSOs such as Initcia and Skyddsvärnet initiate projects largely through an informal bottom-up approach with networks, personal relationships and dedicated coworkers expressing a need. This reliance on informality within CSOs makes their participation more fragile, as it is dependent on the continuity of their individual counterparts rather than agreements on an organizational level. This leads to the risk of the collaboration being halted or collapsing as the individual leaves. Moreover, it can create a gap as the tacit knowledge might get lost with the move. The GOs, bound by heavier governmental bureaucracy, automatically creates a more structured workflow with members having clearer assignments and short-term goals.

When working in cross-sectorial collaborations this top-down versus bottom - up approach can lead to tensions due to two reasons:

Firstly, the top-down approach GOs are implementing, forces some directives that are not necessarily applicable on the local challenges. NOA mentioned getting tasked with counteracting the recruitment of youths to gangs well before it became a local problem. In the early 2020s, the problem became reality and by then they were prepared to face it. This is an example of where the top-down approach of GOs, in unison with a substantial resources, allows for long-term projects, dealing with "what might come" - a luxury CSOs do not have. CSOs, on the other hand, usually have a strong sense of the local challenges, giving them specialized roles, dealing with a narrow problem overview. Working this way gives them a direct contact with the people in need and can generate a detailed perspective of the local challenges. This asymmetry can lead to CSOs feeling put aside as they notice local problems without having the support of GOs in trying to fix it. Nilsson and Ritzén (2023) concludes that a hybrid structure where hierarchical and horizontal structures are combined enables long-term innovation in ecosystems. Further the authors mention its applicability to collaborations where governmental authorities are involved in grand challenges.

Secondly, using different models for initiating projects affects the innovation process in cross-sector collaborations as the top-down approach often gives clear boundaries to work

within. The bottom-up approach allows for a more agile workflow with experimentation and fast iterations. However, this approach can be difficult to sustain in larger projects with several involved actors having different resources (Bryson, Crosby, and Stone 2015).

Moreover, when project initiation is driven by external mandates rather than problem descriptions created by those closest to the problem, collaboration risks becoming hierarchical rather than cooperative. GOs may perceive themselves as the primary actors with CSOs positioned as secondary "helpers", rather than equal partners with valuable perspectives and expertise. Over time, this dynamic can undermine trust and reduce the willingness of CSOs to participate in formal initiatives where their insights are not recognized or utilized. The difference in how projects are initiated, combined with the often significant difference in financial resources and organizational size, creates an imbalance within the collaborations where the CSOs almost exclusively and by default is placed in a position of dependence to the GOs. As a result, the CSOs are not seen as equal partners or consultant, but rather as an outsider, being forced to be there. To ensure effective collaboration, a mechanism is needed where bottom-up signals from CSOs inform top-down strategies in a more integrated way. Fortier and Coulter (2021) points to three major conclusions for aligning the collaborations. Firstly, all involved actors must strengthen their ability to cooperate. For CSOs this would mean to learn to manage the power asymmetries and GOs must adjust their behavior and practices to give CSOs more power and legitimacy. Secondly, a trust must be built between the actors where the evidence of delivery is adapted to its resources and core operations ensuring GOs do not judge "a fish by its ability to climb a tree". Lastly, the authors point out the importance of discussing the frames of the collaboration, ensuring the alignment and understanding of the objectives. This would allow for an early local engagement with shared goals.

Bryson, Crosby, and Stone (2015), empathize the power of deciding on initial conditions within the collaboration, with formal agreements. Doing so have proven to be effective as accountability among the involved actors automatically sets in, especially when the collaboration lacks a strong leadership. More importantly, formalizing early agreements around both purpose and roles helps reduce the power imbalance created by different initiation models. When collaboration begins with shared problem framing, defining objectives, and a clear acknowledgment of each actor's resources and limitations, trust can be built and sustained throughout the project. This is particularly crucial in contexts marked by legal uncertainty and when cultural differences exists between the involved actors. Integrating a hybrid model with both top-down and bottom-up approaches where the strategic direction is decided on based upon informed insights from grassroot levels enables a better collaboration.

5.2 Structural Differences Creates Uneven Power Balance

The involved organizations describes having structural differences. GOs mostly have functional and formal structures, with strong and clear hierarchical levels and specialized

departments. They usually have the opportunity to create teams when new assignments and projects arise. In contrast, CSOs such as Initcia and Skyddsvärnet are using organic and more informal structures involving low hierarchy, flexibility in roles, and high adaptability. These differences are a result of nature of the organizations' core missions, funding, resources, and size. The GOs are typically bound by formal requirements and legal obligations whereas CSOs prioritize flexibility to meet the local needs. This is needed and necessary for efficient work when addressing the core operations. However, these structural differences can create friction when trying to align activities and make decisions across sectors. As CSOs are able to work with a higher flexibility they can often act quickly. Their informal ways of working allows them to adapt and take action even without full documentation and understanding of the problem at hand. The GOs expressed a jealousy towards the CSOs quick response time and showed an understanding of their frustration of large projects taking time. Nevertheless, while GOs need correct documentation and approval from higher authorities to initiate projects, their working methods often allow for some flexibility once the projects are running.

Literature on cross-sector collaborations supports this finding, suggesting that successful partnerships often depend on the balance between formal structures that provide stability and informal relationships that offer flexibility and trust. The four dimensions mentioned earlier by Fortier and Coulter (2021), the relationship, alignment, resources and organizational capacity are clearly reflected on by the interviewees. Several of the interviewed GOs are hesitant to collaborate with CSOs due to regulatory constraints limiting the extent of information sharing. This weakens the relationship from both sides as CSOs are excluded from critical information necessary for an active involvement in collaborations. Moreover, the GOs have no opportunity to build trust towards the CSOs as that trust is never put to the test. Furthermore, many CSOs describes a misalignment of goals as the involved actors often struggle to understand each others objectives within the projects. Lastly, the difference in funding and capacity are evident leading to challenges as the GOs are backed by governmentally set budgets, creating a stable environment. On the other hand, the CSOs struggles with inconsistencies when initiating projects and collaborations. The short-term planning perspective hinders CSOs from truly being able to commit to projects. These pre-existing conditions make it hard for CSOs to be heard from the very beginning of the collaboration setting a norm of not being too helpful.

Murphy, Perrot, and Rivera-Santos (2012) emphasize that structural misalignment can lead to cross-sectoral collaborations to fail if not properly managed. Particularly, the rigid structures of GOs tend to assume a dominant position in collaborations, leading to the contributions from the CSOs to lessen. As a result, smaller actors often experience a "learned helplessness," where repeated marginalization reduces their initiative and engagement in future collaborations.

Therefore, cross-sector collaborations must have an approach where the CSOs are being recognized as equal partners or consultants by the GOs. The challenge for CSOs to prove themselves worthy of a spot in the project can be appointed their to their smaller size, limited resources, and lack of formal mandate. Their contribution is not always seen as equal to the contribution of GOs and this view of CSOs not being able to contribute, hinders effective cross-sectorial collaborations. Nevertheless, when collaboration is based on trust

and driven by individuals with cross-sector experience this changes. In the interview with representatives from Skyddsvärnet, it became evident that long-standing partnerships with municipalities, enables smoother cooperation and more mutual influence.

5.3 Differing Internal Workflows

The different internal cultures and workflows between CSOs and GOs also lead to tensions in collaborations. While CSOs often prioritize being agile and have rapid response to problems, GOs ensure their procedures are followed which in itself reduces risk. This mismatch often results in CSOs feeling "invited but not integrated" (representative from Initcia), which undermines the potential that civil society perspectives could bring to the collaborations and its innovation processes. Several interviewees from CSOs described a sense of symbolic inclusion, where they are brought into projects at a late stage, just to perform predefined tasks rather than be a part of the decision making. This dynamic contributes to frustration for the CSOs and a perceived lack of respect for their expertise and local knowledge.

Furthermore, organizational culture and workflows complicates collaboration in cross-sectorial collaborations. As seen in the interviews, an unwillingness to deviate from established routines within the organization exists, this is especially noticeable within GOs. NOA's representative noted that skepticism towards change is deeply rooted in the safety provided by "doing it the way we have always done" (representative from NOA). This is consistent with Rehman et al. (2021), who highlight how organizational support as well as leadership support are critical for ensuring to cultural resistance to change.

Moreover, GOs seem to have caution deeply rooted into the cultures, particularly when it comes to sharing sensitive information. This is driven not only by legal factors but also by internal norms of control and a way of minimizing risk. CSOs, in contrast, often operate in environments where information flows more freely and decision-making is distributed across teams. CSOs have accepted the sort of "give everything you can but get little in return" (representative from Skyddsvärnet) - partnership that often forms when collaborating across sectors on sensitive issues affecting youths. This imbalance is rooted in legal barriers; however, it shows an underlying difference in how trust, legitimacy, and knowledge are divided between the involved actors. While CSOs are often expected to provide insights and detailed knowledge, they are frequently excluded from critical information held by GOs regarding decision making. This not only limits CSOs' ability to act proactively but also reinforces their supportive position whose perspectives are consulted but not prioritized. Such one directional transparency can lead to frustration, less motivation, and reduced long term engagement from CSOs. In turn, GOs may miss out on useful knowledge by failing to take the perspectives of CSOs into account. As Mattessich and Johnson (2018) argue, effective collaboration requires a balance within the structures, pointing to the importance of having defined roles, shared purpose, and clear procedures. Moreover, qualities such as trust, mutual respect, and open communication are highly regarded in collaborations. When one actor dominates the flow of information or decision-making, the relationship is damaged, and the partnership risks becoming too hierarchical. To ensure fair and effective collaboration, early structures must sup-

port mutual information sharing, transparency, and accountability otherwise the power imbalances risk being reinforced rather than resolved.

5.4 Legal Understanding and Barriers

One of the most mentioned barriers for information sharing is the difficulty of interpreting and understanding legal frameworks regarding information sharing. Although parts of the law enables collaboration, there is widespread uncertainty and fear of misinterpretation, particularly regarding GDPR and Social Service Act. As emphasized by Gakh (2015), legal frameworks that authorize collaboration, rather than enforce it, are crucial to creating flexibility in collaborations.

Nevertheless, the findings indicate that it is not the legal structures it self that hinders collaboration and information sharing, but rather the individuals lack of understanding of the law. The Social Services Act, describing the level of information sharing allowed among the social services and other actors as mentioned in chapter 3 creates a misalignment among the workers. The formulation, centering on the absence of harm for the individual and his/her closest related, creates a significant degree of subjectivity, leaving much of the decision making to individual judgment. Such open ended wording can result in cautious interpretations, where actors may not share information even in situations where it could improve collaboration or lead to better support for the individual. The implications of this legal phrasing and its effect on cross-sector collaboration will be explored in more detail later in the thesis.

This culture of caution, particularly among social service actors, slows down cross-sector collaboration, as mentioned by NOA, Järfälla municipality, Initcia, Skyddsvärnet and school representatives. Rather than actively seeking a better understanding of the legal exceptions that do exist, individuals prioritize not taking any action due to the fear of wrong doing. This leads to collaborations being halted and overall displays a reactive, rater than proactive legal framework where fear outweighs collaboration. To address this, Järfälla municipality used a consultant to compile a document stating clearly what the legal boundaries are and what can be done. Initiatives like this would simplify the communication between actors and remove uncertainties.

The newly implemented Act on the Obligation to Provide Information to Law Enforcement Authorities has been put into place to reduce this uncertainty. By clearly stating that if necessary in regards to the crime preventing activities, departments must share information. Here the government is trying to ensure better transparency allowing for streamlining of investigations. However, the new act does not cover the information sharing to CSOs and does not open the door for the social services to share information with other than the police and other crime-preventing authorities. Moreover, the new, modified version of the Social Services Act is intended to help with exactly this. By ensuring that workers are allowed to work preventative with a deeper focus on crime prevention, the social services will have more mandate to do what is necessary for preventing crime.

All in all this shows the need for better understanding of the legal boundaries, the need for legislative changes allowing for more information to be shared and a clear and standardized

interpretation of the law across sectors.

5.5 Potential for AI Implementation

Despite the cautious stance towards AI, there is a broad recognition of its huge potential in cross-sector collaborations. The empirical findings suggest several key areas where AI could be implemented to help both in the day-to-day operations of the actors and in cross-sector collaborations as mentioned in table 4.1:

One of the opportunities highlighted across the interviews is the potential of AI to *simplify information sharing* between actors in cross-sector collaborations. Organizations such as Skyddsvärnet and Initcia emphasized the challenges of inconsistent communication structures, limited transparency between actors, and legal uncertainty. All of which hinder effective collaboration. The use of AI tools, with structured knowledge databases, could help standardize ways of reporting, enabling safe information sharing, and would help the flow of critical information. Berryhill et al. (2019) argue that effective public-sector AI must be built on flexible structures and a high degree of data sharing. This must firstly be true within the organizations to be helpful in collaborations with external partners. Nevertheless, the successful implementation of such systems does not only require a technical solutions but also shared interpretations of the law as well as an agreement across sectors. Without these in place, changes in infrastructure regarding technical solutions will not resolve the problems with collaboration over sectors.

AI was also mentioned as a tool for *evaluating past initiatives*. Interviewees from NOA and Skyddsvärnet highlighted the value of using AI to analyze the past initiatives to get a much faster understanding of the effects of ongoing and past initiatives, especially in regards to interventions aimed at reducing youth criminality. This aligns with findings from Tekic and Füller (2023), who argue that AI enables data-driven learning in innovation management. However, many CSOs do not have structures for gathering data that would be necessary to do this type of analysis. Their informal and flexible ways of working rarely have a systematic structure for documentation. Due to this, the potential for AI in evaluation is not just a technical challenge but a question of organizational capacity.

Another widely discussed area of application was the *automation of documentation*. Organizations such as Initcia, NOA, Göteborgs Stadsmission, and Täby Ungdomsjour reported that administrative work often use a lot of resources that would be needed doing more operational work. AI tools that streamline report writing, generate case notes, or summarize meetings could improve efficiency, especially in administrative roles. Lee and Dourish (2024) argue that an understanding of the different cultures and organizational structures are vital for the implementation of AI. However, as of now the AI usage in the involved actors, remains informal and driven by individual curiosity rather than an organizational strategy. To utilize its full potential, AI must be formally integrated into workflows, backed up by policies stretching over organizations, ethical guidelines, and training. This is especially true in environments dealing with vulnerable populations otherwise unregulated AI use may introduce risks that outweigh its benefits.

AI's capabilities in *pattern recognition* was also discussed in a promising way. Initcia, in

particular, highlighted the possibility of using AI to detect early warning signs of youth at risk or to analyze social patterns that are otherwise difficult to find. In sectors such as healthcare and law enforcement, AI has already proven its ability to find complex trends (Khalifa and Albadawy 2024). Nevertheless, several interviewees expressed caution for relying too much on AI tools without having a careful human oversight. There is a risk that AI models, if poorly trained or applied in an uncritical manner, will reinforce societal biases, particularly when applied to marginalized communities. This concern is backed by Goldsteen, Farkash, and Hind (2024), who emphasize that trust in AI must be based in transparency and accountability. This means not only to analyze AI results critically but also to give the AI a wide range of data to consider.

Järfälla Municipality raised the potential use of AI in *automating situational analysis* and particularly in environments where gang activity and social marginalization is present. The idea is to use real time data to support fast and correct decision making. The European Commission (2021) has promoted such AI tools as essential in the context of public safety. However, for this work as intended, municipalities must invest in infrastructure together with CSOs and come to long term cross-organizational agreements. Without these, AI tools may not move beyond its initial stages and risk not being integrated to the fullest in organizational workflows.

Together, these findings point to the need for a shift in the cultural and managerial parts of organizations. The hesitation among social service workers is not necessarily due to legal constraints, but is a result of a lack of legal understanding and a culture shaped by risk minimization which often is too cautious. As several interviewees noted, individuals often avoid taking action not because they are not allowed to do it but rather because they are uncertain about how to interpret the law.

This "culture of caution" slows down collaboration and innovation. As such, training initiatives that focuses on the existing legal frameworks and its exceptions, particularly GDPR and social service laws, are critical for streamlining cross-sector collaborations. Legal experts must clarify the legal boundaries and make them understandable for even an untrained eye. This will allow for better innovation processes and allow for more experimentation in collaborations.

Finally, to use the full potential of AI in cross-sector collaborations, power differences between GOs and CSOs must be addressed. CSOs are often brought in late, given limited roles, and are expected to adapt to structures defined by the GOs. This dynamic risks reinforcing a mentality of smaller actors not being equal to the larger ones, limiting their ability to help shape strategic innovation. That's why the implementing AI into future cross-sector collaboration needs to be built together and not just rolled out from the top for the large organizations.

6. Conclusion

Through out the interviews, it became apparent that cross-sector collaborations are facing several challenges. However, when facing grand challenges, using this type of information sharing networks can have a huge impact on the result. Implementing AI can support these collaborations between CSOs and GOs. From the findings, four main conclusions can be drawn.

Cross-sector collaborations are often hindered by the cultural and structural differences between the sectors. GOs have a much more rigid structure with hierarchical levels and more formalized processed, where as CSOs have to rely more on flexible working methods to handle the situations. This misalignment creates friction with CSOs being marginalized in strategic decisions, despite their expertise.

A major barrier for effective information sharing is not necessarily the legal framework it self but rather an uncertainty about how to interpret them. This leads to a cautious stance where actors, especially among social services workers where the fear of legal repercussions is present. This creates a reactive workflow and slows down information sharing and creates a frustration in regards to the collaborations with the social services.

Currently, AI is used in a informal and inconsistent level among the organizations. However, the potential is widely recognized and four major areas is described to where it should be implemented. Simplifying information sharing, evaluation of past efforts, streamlining documentation, and automating situational analysis is where the AI have the biggest opportunities. However, this requires clear ethical guidelines, legal clarity, and cross-sector agreements to be implemented across sectors.

For its implementation to be effective and for AI to reach its full potential, mutual trust and respects must be present. The legal guidelines must be translated into practical frameworks and training must be focused on how to use the AI efficiently and responsively. Lastly, the implementation must be created with all sectors in mind where CSOs are allowed to state their opinion rather than just top-down decisions.

6.1 Proposed solution

To improve future cross-sector collaborations and to better use the potential of AI in complex societal challenges, organizations should consider the following during projects:

- Use a hybrid model of top-down and bottom up approach when initiating collaborations - The initial strategic decisions should come from leadership while operational design must consider the opinions of the workers on the ground.
- Set clear goals and break them down into objectives - At the start of every project a discussion should be held about the main goals and targets of the project. However, the discussion should include a part where the aims of the individual actor is expressed. This will ensure a better understanding of each other and will align the

individual goals to the main target.

- Openly discuss each actors strength, limitations and cultures - Doing this early in the process will reduce friction and build mutual understanding.
- Appoint a dedicated coordinator - Decide on one individual who to lead the project. Doing so will ensure coordination progress and alignment between actors. This promotes accountability as each actor becomes responsible for their promised deliveries.
- Decide on a temporal culture and structure - The coordinator should ensure a working structure and a "project culture" where openness and understanding is promoted over time.

Moreover, to create smoother alignment for cross-sector collaborations the organizations should continuously consider and improve the following:

- Improve the legal understanding - By continuously seeking to clarify where the legal boundaries are and seeking guidance from legal experts, the collaborations would be streamlined.
- Implement AI systems gradually - By slowly integrating AI-tools for simpler tasks such as automating documentation the trust and understanding of its value will increase. The AI-tools should be implemented across sectors to ensure alignment.
- Provide basic AI training - To encourage the use of the AI-tools and increase the understanding of the technology, training should be encouraged.
- Establish shared processes for evaluation of past efforts - Having evaluations within the collaborations will ensure better alignment and a deeper understanding of each other.

If these points are taken into consideration when moving forward, cross-sector collaborations are likely to become more efficient, information sharing will improve, and overall project satisfaction and outcomes will be enhanced.

6.1.1 Future Work

While this thesis outlines several ways AI could support innovation and information sharing in cross-sector collaborations, each of the proposed solutions could be explored in more detail. Future studies could take a closer look at how the solutions mentioned above actually work in practice. It would also be useful to look into how trust, clear legal guidelines, and better training affect the chances of successful AI use in projects like these.

6.1.2 Reflections on Limitations

As outlined in the methodology chapter, there are several limitations that influence the result of this study. Since the research is based on a case study of the IBob-project, the findings are to some extent context specific and may not be directly applicable to other types of organizations or collaborations. Additionally, the analysis is built on interviews with a limited number of individuals, meaning that the conclusions are strongly affected by their personal experiences and perspectives. The technical aspect of AI were also

not in focus, which means that some insights into AI solutions may be lacking. These limitations should be taken into account when interpreting the results, but they do not undermine the overall aim of understanding opportunities and challenges in cross-sector collaborations.

6.1.3 Contributions

This thesis contributes to research by investigating the factors that affect cross-sectorial collaborations and how AI can be implemented and support innovation within them. It examines the structural, cultural and legal challenges involved, along with the conditions for integrating AI into the workflow of such collaborations. Based on local and operative insights from the Bob initiative and IBob-project, the study identifies practical barriers and reveals a new perspective on the tensions that arise when actors with different resources and mandates collaborate. While rooted in crime prevention for youths, the results may be applicable to other public innovation work. Given the scarcity of research on joint innovation processes in this setting, this thesis offers a step towards filling that gap.

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A. Interview Guide

Interview Guide

Background

- Can you describe your role, how long you have worked in this role, and your responsibilities within the organization?

Current Work Methods

- Can you describe what a typical day looks like for you? For example, what did you do yesterday?
- How do you receive new projects and information about them?
- Can you describe how you/your organization plan a new project? Do you currently have any ongoing projects aimed at reducing the risk of youth involvement in gangs?
- Do you use explicit innovation processes, such as design thinking, agile methods, or other models? In other words, how does the organization structure its work?
- How does internal collaboration and information exchange function within your organization?
- How does collaboration and information exchange work with external organizations and government agencies?
- Is there a significant difference in how information is exchanged between civil organizations and government agencies?
- Can you describe how you experience the exchange of information with other actors?
  a. What challenges do you face in this process?
- What tools or methods do you use to improve information exchange and collaboration with external parties?
- Can you describe how you work to develop new initiatives and measures together with other actors?
  a. What challenges do you encounter in this work?
- When working on projects that address complex societal challenges, what do you think is needed to make the work run more smoothly? (Are there any specific aspects of your processes that need improvement?)
- Are there any support functions within your organization that would help facilitate the work?
- Are there any external support functions that would help facilitate the work?

Innovation Strategies

- Can you share examples of improvements that have been implemented in collaboration with other actors regarding work methods?
- Are there any factors that drive or hinder improvements within your organization?
- Are there any factors that drive or hinder improvements between different actors? Can you give an example?

AI Implementation

- Are you familiar with generative AI and its potential applications? Have you used it yet? How do you see its relevance to your work?
- What do you see as the potential benefits or risks of integrating AI into your current work methods?

Legal Aspects

- What legal limitations affect your collaboration on complex societal challenges? Are you allowed to share and receive all the information you need?
- What legislative changes do you think would be needed to facilitate collaboration with other actors?

Final Questions

- What are the biggest challenges you face due to being either a civil organization or a government agency?
- Do you ever evaluate work methods or initiatives afterward? If so, how is this done?

B. Interview Guide

Interview Guide

Background

1. Can you briefly describe your role at the school? How long have you worked in this role?

Work with At-Risk Youth

2. What does the general work look like with students who are at risk of going down the wrong path?
3. How do you notice if a student is at risk? What are the early warning signs? And how often does it happen?
4. How clear are the guidelines from the National Agency for Education (Skolverket) regarding how to handle at-risk youth? Are they easy to follow, and how well do they work?
5. Are there any specific guidelines that you follow? If yes, do you follow them 100%, or are they more general?
6. How do you act if you suspect a student is on their way into a criminal lifestyle?
7. Have you received training in this area? If yes, does it include all staff levels – from principal to youth workers?
8. What initiatives does the school have to support students who are at risk? Are these in line with Skolverket's guidelines and frameworks?
9. What do you wish Skolverket had done to improve this work?
10. Do you have any preventive initiatives? If yes, what do you see as the biggest obstacles in the preventive work?
11. Do you have any examples of a situation where the preventive work was successful or unsuccessful?
12. What do you think schools and society should do to handle these children?

Collaboration and Structures

14. Which actors do you collaborate with the most when it comes to at-risk youth? Can you describe that collaboration?
15. What would be needed to improve it?
16. Is there anything you feel is missing in the collaboration with other actors?

17. How do you perceive the parents' attitude towards the issue overall? Are they engaged?
18. How do you think the work and collaboration function over time – is it reactive or proactive

Views on Technology and AI

19. Do you use AI in any way, and what is your view on the possibility of using AI or other digital tools in working with at-risk students?
20. There have been reports that Snapchat and similar apps are used to recruit young people – how do you see the school's ability to act on this?
21. Do you see any risks in implementing more digital tools in schools?

Challenges and Needs

22. What do you find most challenging in the work with at-risk youth?
23. What kind of support do you think you need more of – internally or externally?

Closing Questions

24. Is there anything else you would like to add about the school's role in preventing youth from going down the wrong path?

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